Sikkim, Nepal and Kashmir; as a result of this, it came into direct contact with the Tibetans.

If the great Himalayas acted as a barrier between the Indian subcontinent and Tibet, access from China was equally, if not more, difficult with the Kunlun Mountains bounding the plateau towards the north. Ironically, in ancient times, the easiest approaches into Lhasa were from the south: the Chumbi Valley between Sikkim and West Bhutan, and through Tawang which lay just beyond the eastern extremity of Bhutan. At the other end was the route that linked Ladakh to Sinkiang via Nubra, then through the Aksai Chin to Lhasa. The Chinese pilgrims who furnished us with such valuable insights into early Indian history in the fifth and seventh centuries avoided Tibet, choosing instead to wind around through the circuitous route of Chinese Turkestan and the mountain ranges of northwest India.

The whole of Eastern Tibet, formed by the frontiers of U and Kongbo to the borders of China proper, was known as Kham and the inhabitants as Khampa. It included an enormous expanse of wild mountainous country extending some 1,300 kilometres from west to east and 1,000 kilometres from north to south, and was the catchment area for the Yangtze Kiang, the Mekong and the Salwen rivers. While the northern limit of this region divided the basins of the Hwang Ho and the Yangtze Kiang rivers, towards the south it extended to the frontiers of Assam and Yunnan. Given its immediate proximity to China, the political organization of the region was exceedingly complicated.

Over the centuries, this region appears to have been parcelled out amongst a number of small semi-independent states and nomadic hordes who were ruled by their own petty chieftains; they professed no allegiance either to Peking or to Lhasa. The power struggle between Tibet and China, with the latter every now and then claiming suzerainty, meant nothing as far as the governance of the region was concerned. The appointment of lamas was almost exclusively done by Lhasa, which was forever trying to get Eastern Tibet into its sphere of influence. As for the local Khampas, they feared and dreaded the bigoted rule of the lamas, preferring their own ‘half-savage’ independence that meant they constantly had to steer a careful course between the Lhasa lamas and the officials from Peking.

Originally the districts that constituted Eastern Tibet extended right up to the western frontier of China proper—to Gansu, Szechuan, and Yunnan